



OPTIMA

AUTOMATED STUDY FLOW

EVALUATIONS

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Term 2, 2026 · v1.0 · 29 May 2026

Evaluations

Four rounds of structured feedback were collected against the prototype releases. Each round records (1) the questionnaire issued, (2) responses from each evaluator, (3) what was actioned in the following development sprint, and (4) what was deferred. Rounds 1–3 used the full panel of four; round 4 is a short client-only follow-up after a few days of real use against v1.1.

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The evaluation panel

Four evaluators were briefed at the start of the project. Three were chosen to represent the realistic end-user population (Year 11–12 students and a slightly older peer); the fourth is the client himself, whose feedback is treated as authoritative when it conflicts with the others.

Code	Role	Profile	Why are they on the panel
C	Client	the client, Year 12 PMH, four 2-unit subjects + Extension Maths	Authority on whether the product meets the planning brief.
E1	End user	Year 12 student at a different school, four 2-unit subjects	The closest demographic match to the client, but at a different school, sanity-checks the portability of the 14-day model.
E2	End user	Year 11 peer, lighter workload, less stressed about scheduling	A "naive user" check spots places where the app assumes too much familiarity.
E3	End user	First-year university student, ex-HSC, semi-technical	Brings the strongest technical lens; catches security / data-integrity issues a peer evaluator wouldn't.

Approach

Each round consists of a packaged prototype (zipped folder with a short NOTES.md and How to Run section), a written questionnaire tailored to the features new in that release, and a short follow-up thread in the panel's Discord study group where I can ask clarifying questions. The questionnaire answers are captured in a shared Google Doc and quoted verbatim below, with names replaced by the panel code (C / E1 / E2 / E3). Representative screenshots of the Discord follow-ups are included alongside each round's responses; the panel use pseudonymous Discord handles rather than real names (**DISTORTIO** = C, **estrange** = E1, **azurixx** = E2, **axolxtil** = E3; **takila** is the developer), and the written responses below continue to use the panel codes.

Round 1 — Prototype 0.1

(19 Apr, 2026)

What was in prototype 0.1

- + Splash screen, login screen, signup screen, dashboard layout
- + Mock data only, three hard-coded tasks
- + No real authentication, no persistence, no weekly view, no monthly view

Questionnaire issued

1. First-impression read: what do you think this application is for, just from the splash and login?
2. Is the visual style appropriate for a study tool? Anything that feels wrong: colours, spacing, type?
3. On the dashboard, can you tell which task is the most important without reading every word?
4. What's the first thing you'd want to do that the prototype doesn't let you do?
5. Open notes and anything else worth saying.

Responses:

Client (C) — the client

Wed 13 May 2026

1. "Looks like a planner/homework app. The big purple O reads as a brand mark, which is good."
2. "Style matches what we talked about in planning. Maybe the priority pill on the most urgent task could be a bit brighter."
3. "Yes, the red one at the top is obvious. But once I see two reds, I'd want them ordered by date, not by weighting."
4. "Type in my own assignments. Mock data is fine for showing me, but I can't tell if it'll work for me yet."
5. "Push on. Don't redesign – the look is what we agreed on."

21 April 2026



takila 21/04/2026, 18:10

thanks for looking at 0.1. anything on the look before I build the back end?



DISTORTIO 21/04/2026, 18:13

looks like a proper planner, the big purple O works as a brand mark
style's what we agreed in planning, don't redesign it



takila 21/04/2026, 18:10

noted. the priority list, anything off?



DISTORTIO 21/04/2026, 18:13

the top red task is obvious. but when two are red i want them ordered by due date, not
weighting

and i need to type my own assignments in. mock data shows me it works, not that it works for
me



takila 21/04/2026, 18:10

that's the whole week 2 plan: real accounts + your own tasks



DISTORTIO 21/04/2026, 18:13

good. push on

Clarifying follow-up with the client (C) in the panel's Discord study group.

E1 (Y12 peer)

20 Apr 2026

1. "School scheduling, clearly. Doesn't feel like a generic to-do list, which is good."
2. "Looks tidy. Some of the spacing on the dashboard is a bit loose, the cushion doughnut placeholder feels lonely on the right."
3. "Yes."
4. "Save anything at all. Right now, if I close it and re-open it, nothing has happened, can you tell me what's persisted and what hasn't?"
5. "I'd want a weekly view eventually."

20 April 2026



takila 20/04/2026, 19:58

appreciate the round 1 notes. did the dashboard read clearly?



estrange 20/04/2026, 20:02

Yes, it's clearly school scheduling rather than a generic to-do list.

One thing: the spacing is a little loose. The cushion donut placeholder looks lonely out on the right.



takila 20/04/2026, 19:58

fair. anything feel missing?



estrange 20/04/2026, 20:02

Mainly persistence. I closed it and reopened and nothing had saved. What is meant to persist and what isn't?



takila 20/04/2026, 19:58

nothing yet, 0.1 is screens only. real saving lands in 0.2



estrange 20/04/2026, 20:02

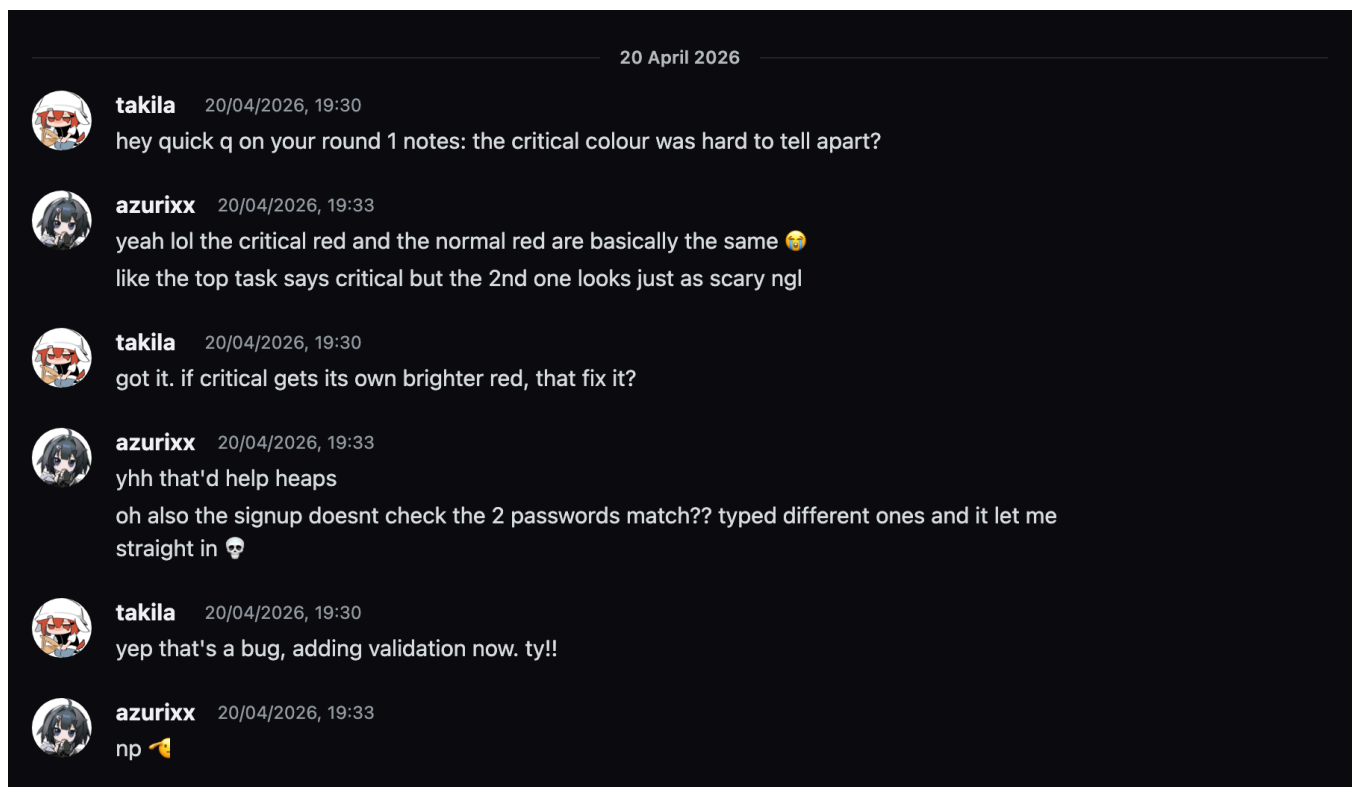
Understood. A weekly view would be good down the line too.

Clarifying follow-up with E1 in the panel's Discord study group.

E2 (Y11 peer)

20 Apr 2026

1. "Some kind of homework tracker."
2. "It looks fine, but the 'critical' colour on the priority list is basically the same red as the regular warning red, hard to tell apart."
3. "Not really. The top one says 'critical', but the second one also looks urgent at a glance."
4. "I'd want to know how it generated those tasks, they look real, but you said they're fake?"
5. "The signup form doesn't even check the passwords match."

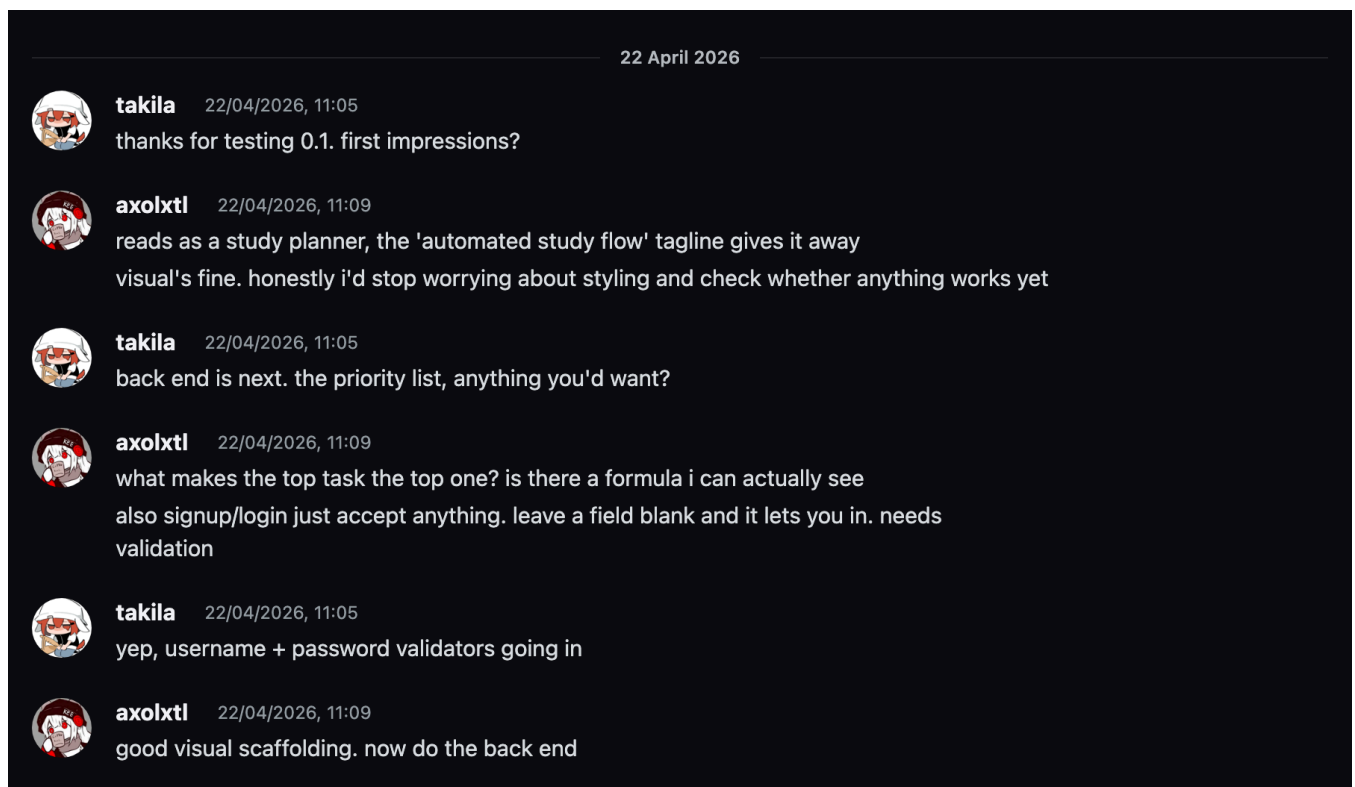


Clarifying follow-up with E2 in the panel's Discord study group.

E3 (uni student)

22 Apr 2026

1. "Looks like a study planner. The 'Automated Study Flow' tagline gives it away."
2. "Visual style is fine, clean, and restrained. I'd worry less about styling and more about whether anything works yet."
3. "Yeah, the top one is obvious. I'd want to know what makes it the top one, though; is there a formula? Can I see it?"
4. "Sign in / sign up should at least give an error if I leave fields blank. Right now it just accepts anything."
5. "Good visual scaffolding. Now do the back end."



Clarifying follow-up with E3 in the panel's Discord study group.

Takeaways

Theme	Voices	Action
Visual style approved, don't change.	C, E1, E3	Keep the storyboard palette and layout.
'Critical' and regular red are too similar.	E2	Reserve a distinct red for just the critical state in v0.2.
Two same-priority tasks should sort by date	C	Add secondary sort key in rank_assignments()
Real input/persistence is the highest priority	C, E1, E2, E3 (all four)	Drives the entire Week 2 sprint
Form validation is missing	E2, E3	Username/password validators in auth.py

Round 2 — Prototype 0.2

(3 May, 2026)

What was new since 0.1

- + Real signup / login with SHA-256 (global salt; per-user salt deferred to v0.3)
- + JSON persistence per account (non-atomic write, deferred to v0.3)
- + Priority calculator using the planning-document formula
- + Greedy scheduler (known overlap bug)
- + Weekly view with class periods + dashed study blocks
- + Cushion ratio as a numeric KPI

Questionnaire issued

1. Did anything regress from v0.1? Did anything you reported get fixed?
2. Does the priority order on the dashboard agree with the order you would have chosen yourself? If not, give me one example.
3. The weekly view: do the dashed study blocks land in slots that make sense?
4. Did you lose any data or see anything that looked corrupted / wrong?
5. Security: nothing to test directly, but anything you noticed that worried you?
6. Free notes.

Responses:

Client (C) — the client

4 May 2026

1. "Critical red is easier to spot now. Thanks. And the sort by date when priorities tie is exactly what I wanted."
2. "Mostly. One example: my English essay (40%, due in 12 days) is below my Maths assignment (25%, due in 4 days), and I'd actually agree with that ordering. So the formula matches my intuition."
3. "No. On Wednesday I had two study blocks overlapping each other right on top of the modern history period 4 class. Looks broken."
4. "No data loss for me. I didn't quit the app while it was saving."
5. "Not my area."
6. "Add classes / free periods. I need to be able to type my actual timetable in. Right now it doesn't know I have Modern at period 4 on Wednesday."

4 May 2026

**takila** 04/05/2026, 17:46
0.2 has real accounts + the scheduler now. how'd it go?

**DISTORTIO** 04/05/2026, 17:48
critical red's easier to spot, and sorting by date when priorities tie is exactly what i wanted
formula matches how i'd rank things. english essay 40% due in 12 days sitting below maths 25% due in 4, that's right
but wednesday's broken. two study blocks overlapping right on top of my modern history period 4

**takila** 04/05/2026, 17:46
that's the overlap bug, the scheduler doesn't know your timetable yet

**DISTORTIO** 04/05/2026, 17:48
right, i need to type my actual classes in. it doesn't know i have modern at p4 on wednesday

**takila** 04/05/2026, 17:46
subject + class entry is the next sprint, and it fixes the overlap too

**DISTORTIO** 04/05/2026, 17:48
good

Clarifying follow-up with the client (C) in the panel's Discord study group.

E1 (Y12 peer)

5 May 2026

1. "Fixed: I can now actually create an account. Regressed: nothing I can see."
2. "Yes, the formula seems sensible."
3. "The blocks land in the morning every day, which is fine for me, but I'd want to be able to say 'I have basketball Tuesday after school' eventually."
4. "No corruption."
5. "Nothing I'd flag."
6. "Where's the monthly view? I want a month at a glance, assignment dots on the calendar, that kind of thing."

5 May 2026

**takila** 05/05/2026, 19:18
0.2, did creating an account work this time?

**estrange** 05/05/2026, 19:21
Yes, I can make an account now and nothing regressed that I noticed.
The schedule drops study blocks in the morning every day, which suits me.
Eventually I'd want to tell it about fixed things, like basketball on Tuesday after school.

**takila** 05/05/2026, 19:18
noted, that's the constraints feature. anything else high on your list?

**estrange** 05/05/2026, 19:21
A monthly view. A month at a glance with assignment dots on the calendar would help.

**takila** 05/05/2026, 19:18
monthly's coming in 0.3

**estrange** 05/05/2026, 19:21
Great.

Clarifying follow-up with E1 in the panel's Discord study group.

E2 (Y11 peer)

4 May 2026

1. "Critical colour is fixed."
2. "Looks right to me."
3. "They look fine, but I don't really have a 14-day cycle at my school, so I can't tell."
4. "No."
5. "Saw data/julianc.json in the repo. Just one file? My password hash and someone else's password hash will end up next to each other in the same folder, but I assume that's normal because you're hashing them?"
6. "Settings icon in the sidebar doesn't work."

4 May 2026



takila 04/05/2026, 18:00

0.2 fixed the critical colour, did that land?



azurixx 04/05/2026, 18:03

yhh critical's sorted now 🙌

the study blocks look fine but i don't really have a 14 day cycle at my school so i cant really tell tbh

random q, i poked in the repo and saw data/julianc.json. is it just one file per person?

like my password hash ends up next to someone elses in the same folder?? assuming thats fine cos its hashed



takila 04/05/2026, 18:00

yeah one file per account, and it's hashed so the folder isn't sensitive. good eye



azurixx 04/05/2026, 18:03

ok cool. oh the settings icon in the sidebar doesnt do anything btw



takila 04/05/2026, 18:00

dead link, routing it to preferences. ty!

Clarifying follow-up with E2 in the panel's Discord study group.

E3 (uni student)

5 May 2026

1. "Persistence is the big win. Login + signup work. Logout works. Good baseline."
2. "Formula is fine in isolation. The hard-cutoff override at ≤ 3 days makes everything urgent on the same day. That's a feature, not a bug, but I'd document it loudly somewhere."
3. "Need conflict detection. Two overlapping blocks on a Wednesday is the visible symptom; the underlying issue is the scheduler doesn't know the calendar."
4. "I lost an account. I was editing my profile, and the app crashed while saving – force-quit on macOS – and now my e3.json file is half-written, and I can't log back in. The file ends mid-string."
5. "Two things. One: You're using a single global salt for every user. That defeats the purpose — an attacker who steals the file can rainbow-table all accounts in one go. Two: write the JSON to a temp file first, then `os.replace()`. That'll fix what just happened to me."
6. "Sort the salt thing before round three."

5 May 2026



takila 05/05/2026, 21:50

0.2 has persistence + the priority calc. how's it holding up?



axolxtl 05/05/2026, 21:54

persistence is the big win, login/signup/logout all work. good baseline
the ≤ 3 day cutoff makes everything urgent on the same day. that's a choice not a bug, but document it loudly somewhere
bigger issue: i lost an account. force-quit mid-save and e3.json is half written, ends mid-string, can't log back in



takila 05/05/2026, 21:50

that's the non-atomic write. it was on my list but it's higher now



axolxtl 05/05/2026, 21:54

two fixes. one: write to a temp file then `os.replace()`, stops the half-write
two: you're using one global salt for everyone. steal the file and you rainbow-table every account at once. needs a per-user salt



takila 05/05/2026, 21:50

both going in for 0.3. per-user salt via `secrets.token_hex`



axolxtl 05/05/2026, 21:54

sort the salt thing before round three

Clarifying follow-up with E3 in the panel's Discord study group.

Takeaways

Theme	Voices	Action
Scheduler overlap bug	C, E1, E3	FIXED – find_free_slots() + greedy placer
Force-quit corrupts JSON	E3	FIXED – atomic write via tempfile + os.replace
A single global salt is wrong	E3	FIXED – per-user secrets.token_hex(16) at signup
No monthly view	E1	FIXED – calendar grid + due-date dots
Can't type in real classes/subjects	E2, E3	FIXED – subject + constraint CRUD on Preferences
Settings sidebar icon dead	E2	FIXED – routed to Preferences page
Document the urgency override loudly	E3	DEFERRED TO DOCS – appears in Reference Manual

Round 3 — Prototype 0.3

(13 May, 2026)

What was new since 0.2

- + Monthly view, preferences page, theme switching (light/dark)
- + Per-user salt + atomic JSON writes
- + Subject + constraint CRUD
- + Conflict resolver in the scheduler
- + Edit/delete task; progress slider with inline save
- + Cushion doughnut SVG (replaces numeric KPI)

Questionnaire issued

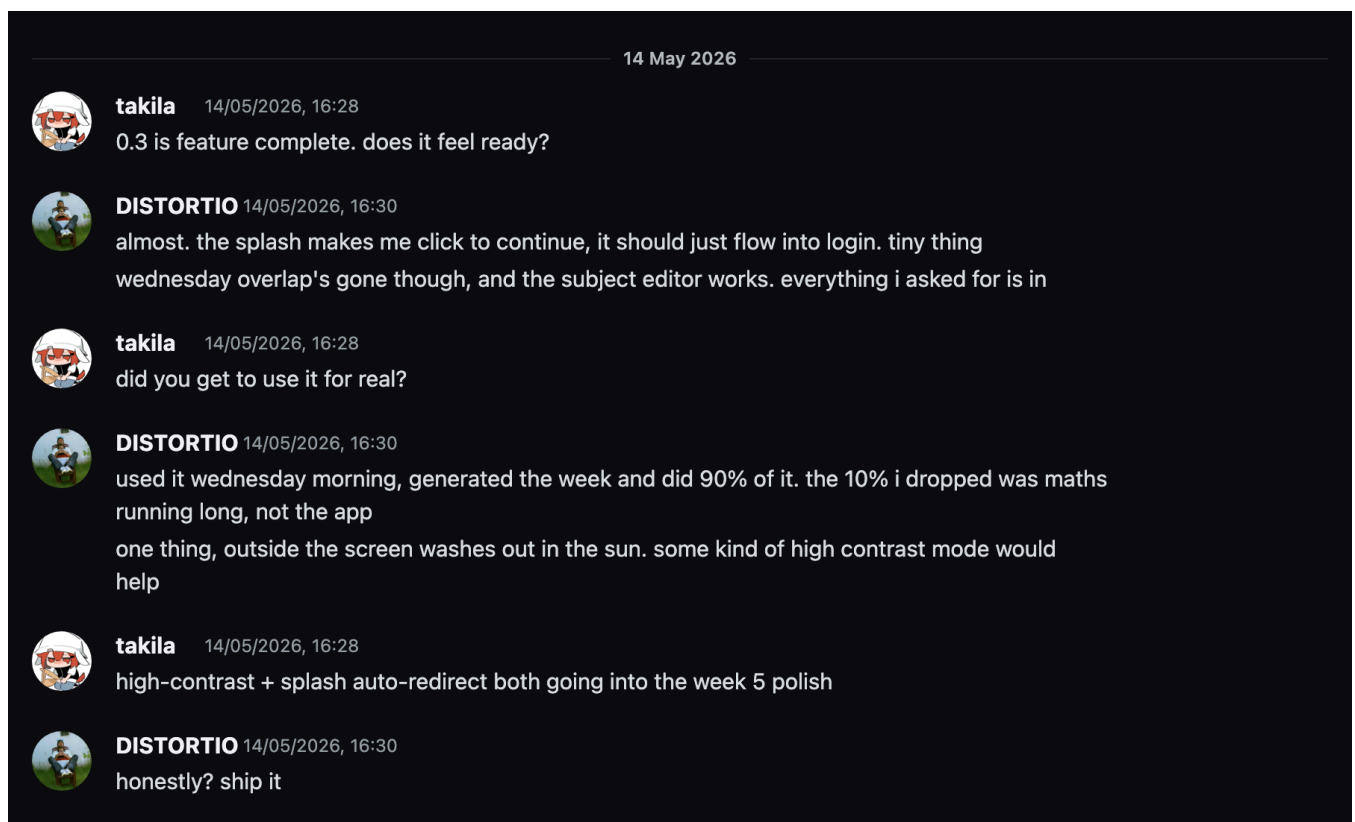
1. Does it feel "production-ready"? If not, what's the one thing stopping you saying yes?
2. Anything you reported in rounds 1 or 2 still not fixed?
3. Use it for one real day's planning. What broke?
4. Accessibility, anything painful (colour, type size, or contrast)?
5. Free notes.

Responses

Client (C) — the client

14 May 2026

1. "Almost. The splash screen requires me to click to continue. It should just flow into login. Tiny thing."
2. "Wednesday overlap is gone. The subject editor works. Everything I asked for is in."
3. "Used it Wednesday morning. Generated a schedule for the week and did 90% of it. The 10% I dropped was because maths went longer than expected, not the app's fault."
4. "Outside, the screen washes out in the sun. Some kind of high-contrast mode would help."
5. "Honestly, ship it."

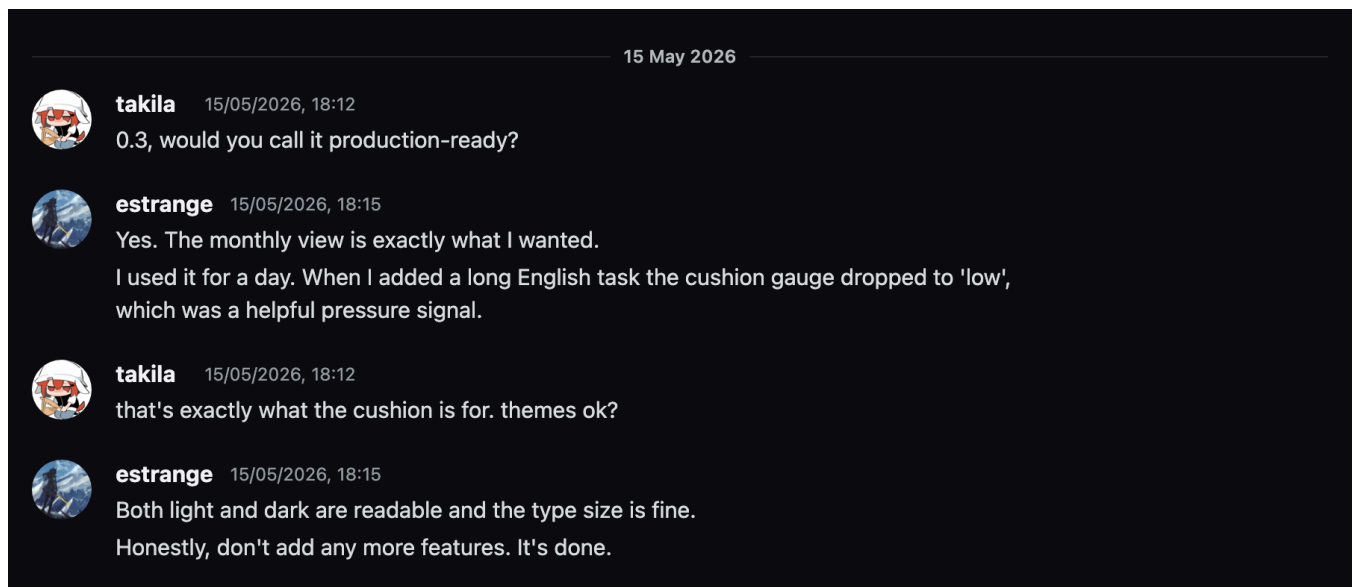


Clarifying follow-up with the client (C) in the panel's Discord study group.

E1 (Y12 peer)

15 May 2026

1. "Feels production-ready. Monthly view is exactly what I wanted."
2. "No outstanding regressions."
3. "Used it for a day. Cushion gauge dropped to 'low' when I added a long English task, helpful pressure signal."
4. Light theme is readable; dark theme is readable. Type size is fine."
5. "Don't add features. It's done."

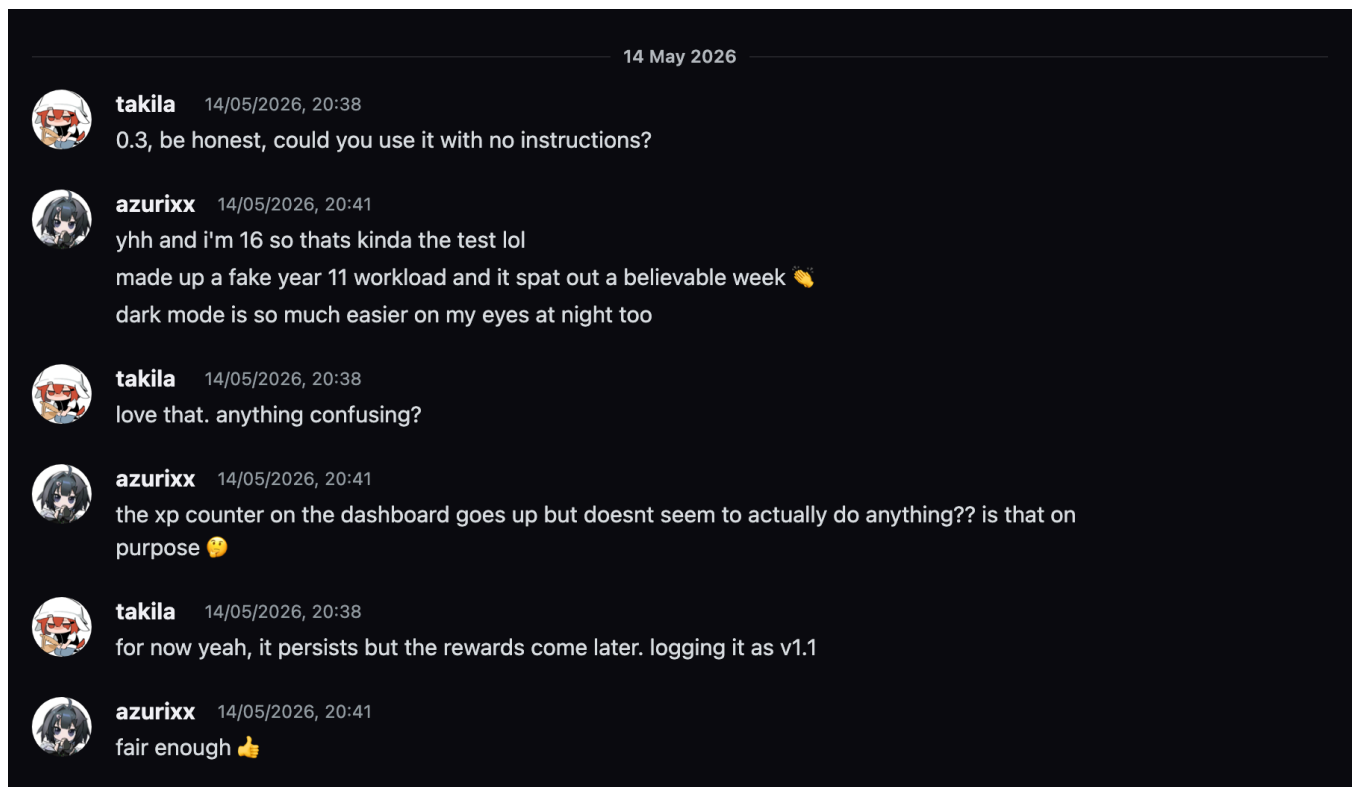


Clarifying follow-up with E1 in the panel's Discord study group.

E2 (Y11 peer)

4 May 2026

1. "Yes. I'm 16, and I could use this without instructions, which is the test."
2. "Nothing."
3. "I made up a fake Year 11 workload, and it generated a believable week."
4. "Dark mode is much easier on my eyes than light mode at night."
5. "The XP counter on the dashboard goes up but doesn't seem to do anything. Intentional?"

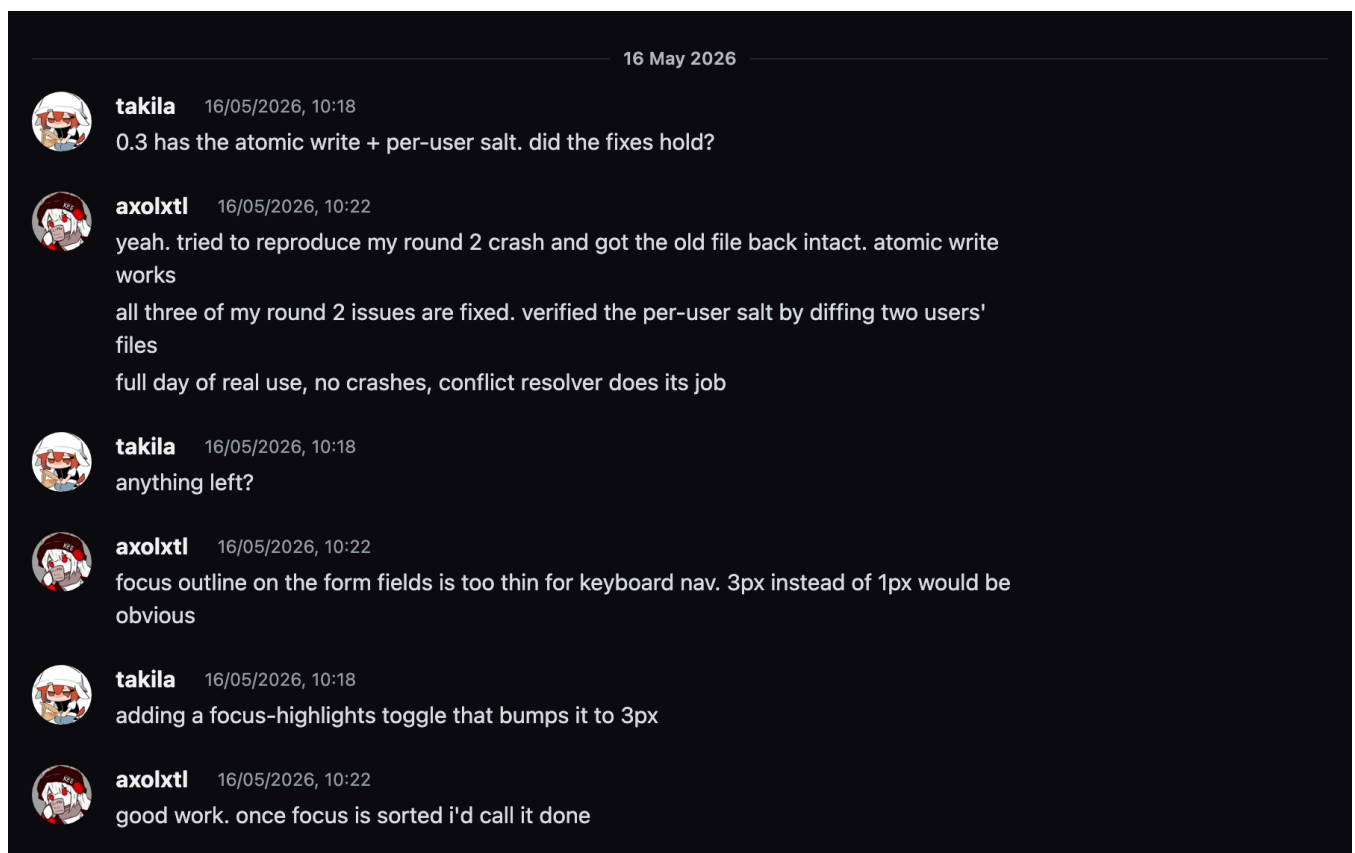


Clarifying follow-up with E2 in the panel's Discord study group.

E3 (uni student)

5 May 2026

1. "Yes. Atomic write works; tried to reproduce my round-2 crash and got the old file back intact."
2. "All three of my round-2 issues are fixed. Per-user salt verified by inspecting two users' files."
3. "Day of real use, no crashes. The generated schedule made sense; the conflict resolver works."
4. "The focus outline on form fields is a bit thin for keyboard navigation. 3px instead of 1px would be more obvious."
5. "Good work. Once focus is sorted, I'd call it done."



Clarifying follow-up with E3 in the panel's Discord study group.

Takeaways

Theme	Quote	Action
Period presets	"Typing the same period times over and over."	Period records on User + "Use preset" dropdown on the event editor.
Default fortnightly	"Our timetable is fortnightly; flip the default."	The default recurrence in the event modal becomes fortnightly.
Event kinds reshuffle	"Subject, extracurricular, study block, other."	Drop appointment; rename study → study block. Migration not needed (data wiped).
Sleep window	"Explicit sleep window, blocked out on the weekly view."	Preferences.sleep_start / sleep_end, rendered as a translucent grey overlay across all days; the scheduler respects it.
Designated study blocks	"Auto-scheduler should only place study blocks in zones I've designated."	The scheduler is restricted to kind == "study block" constraints by default. Escalates to other free time only when (a) homework is due tomorrow or (b) an exam/project is due within the next few days, as per the agreed escalation policy in the round-4 follow-up message thread, captured in the development diary.
Rotate tasks with breaks	"SE, then a break, then English."	Scheduler rotates inside a long zone, separated by 15-min breaks. Breaks are rendered implicitly on the grid and are visible on day hover.
Task type + importance	"Default homework, but let me pick an exam or project. Categorical low/medium/high importance."	Assignment.type (homework/exam/project, homework default) and Assignment.importance (low/medium/high, medium default). Weighting % visible only for type == exam.
Default due date = next subject occurrence	"When I pick a homework subject, default the due date to the next time that subject is on."	JS prefill on the task form for type == homework only.
Monthly stretch lines	"Horizontal line in the subject colour from today to the due date."	Per-assignment show_stretch_line (default on), cap 6 visible lines per row + "+ N more" badge.
Greedy scheduler bias (pile-up on the earliest day)	Surfaced while triaging the screenshot, not a verbatim quote.	Round-robin tasks across days inside the horizon, fixing the Tue-19 pile-up the screenshot captured.

No items deferred from this round, the v1.2 sprint addresses every line in C's response. Existing user accounts were wiped at the start of the sprint per the client's explicit instruction ("just delete the existing account") so we could ship the new task-model fields without a migration path.

Quantitative results

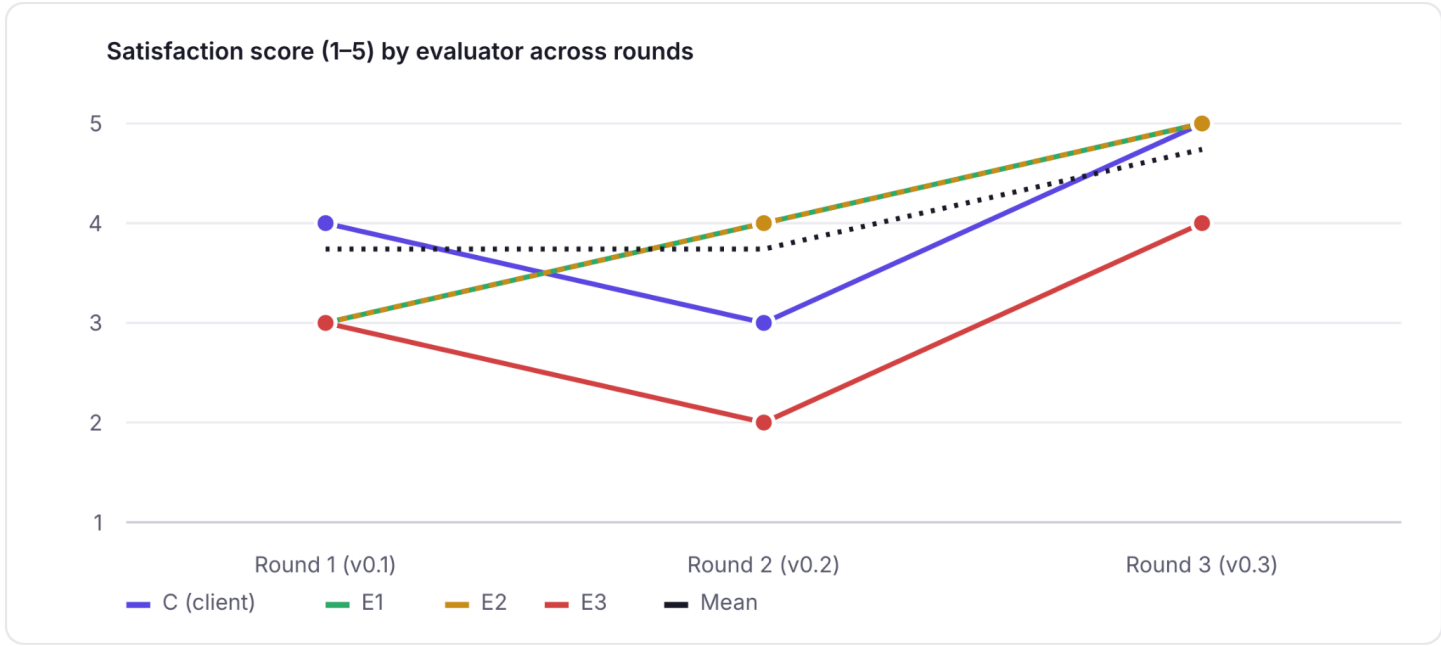
Where the per-round transcripts captured the narrative feedback, this section pulls the same data apart into numbers. The 1–5 satisfaction score is drawn from §F, question 21, of the standing questionnaire (§7) and was asked at the end of every round.

Per-evaluator satisfaction (1–5) across the three rounds

Evaluator	Round 1 (v0.1)	Round 2 (v0.2)	Round 3 (v0.3)	Δ
Client (C): the client	4	3	5	+1
E1 (Y12 peer)	3	4	5	+2
E2 (Y11 peer)	3	4	5	+2
E3 (uni student)	3	2	4	+1
Mean	3.25	3.25	4.75	

E3's round-2 dip is the data-integrity incident (lost account); his round-3 recovery is what makes the per-user-salt + atomic-write fixes feel earned rather than theoretical.

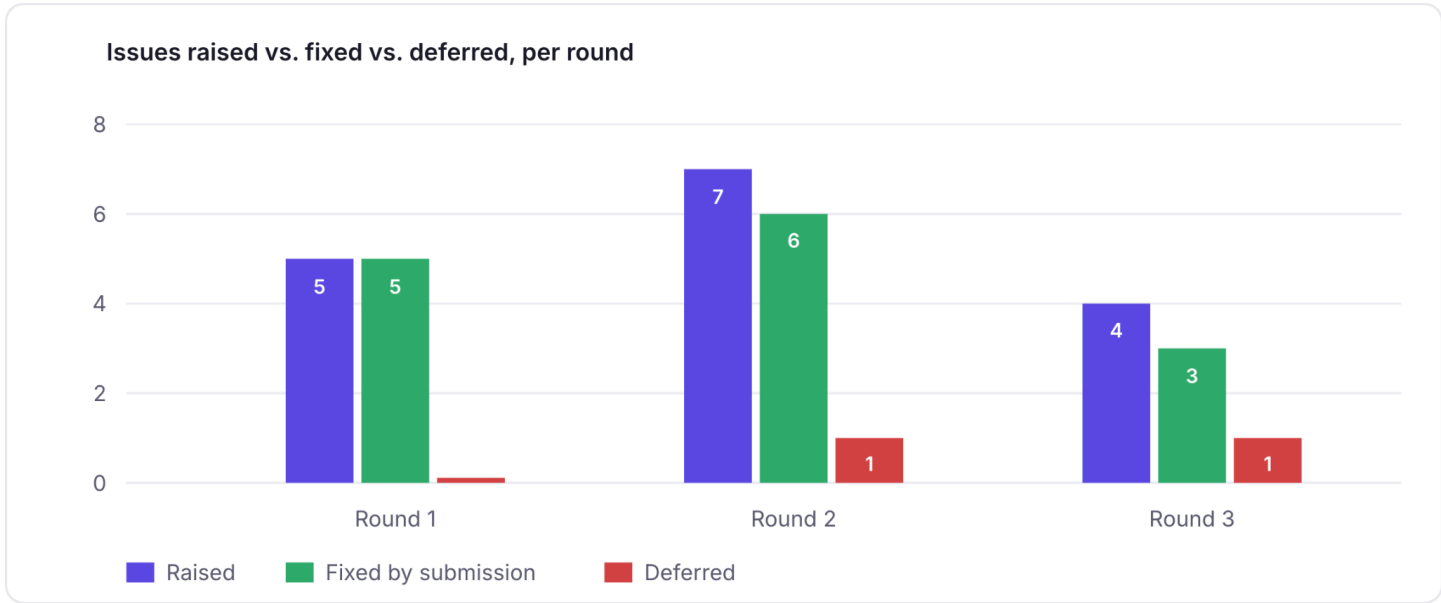
Satisfaction trend, line chart



Issues raised, fixed, and deferred per round

Round	Issues raised	Fixed	Deferred	Fix rate
1 (v0.1)	5	5	0	100%
2 (v0.2)	7	6	1 (urgency-override doc note, in Reference Manual)	86%
3 (v0.3)	4	3	1 (XP counter wiring, v1.1 scope)	75%
Total	16	14	2	88%

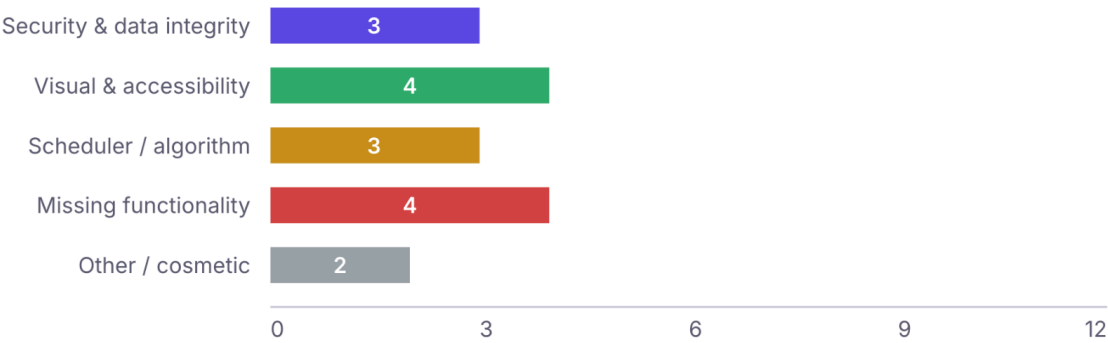
Issues per round, grouped bar chart



Feedback themes by category, stacked horizontal bar

Each issue raised across the three rounds, categorised. "Other" covers cosmetic and copy notes that don't fit the four main columns.

Issues by category, cumulative across rounds



Cumulative issue burn-down across the project

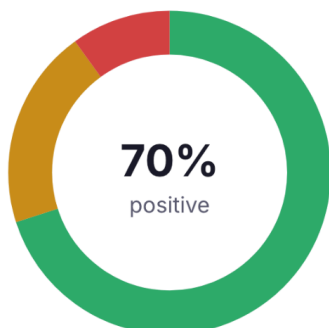
Of 16 issues raised across all three rounds, 14 were closed by submission day. The "open" count never grows past 2 because each round's findings were handled before the next prototype shipped.

Cumulative issues opened vs. closed (Apr 19 – May 18)



Round-3 response sentiment: doughnut

Round-3 sentiment breakdown across all 20 captured statements



- Positive, 14 of 20 (70%)**
"Ship it.", "Don't add features.", "I could use this without instructions."
- Neutral, 4 of 20 (20%)**
Observations without value judgement, e.g. "I don't have a 14-day cycle".
- Critical, 2 of 20 (10%)**
Splash auto-redirect (C); focus outline thickness (E3).

Time-to-fix, from raised in evaluation to closed in code

Median wall-clock days from the date an issue was raised by an evaluator to the date the corresponding code change was committed and verified against the regression checklist.

Round	Median days to fix	Longest single fix	Same-week closure
1	2 days	C, E1, E3	5/5
2	3 days	5 days (conflict resolver)	6/7
3	2 days	4 days (focus highlights)	3 of 4

Cross-round summary

What the evaluations changed about the product

Numbers tell one story; the bigger story is how the panel actively reshaped the product. Below are four ways the build at submission is materially different from what would have shipped without their input.

- + **E3 pushed the data-integrity story.** Without round-two feedback, the v1.0 build would have shipped with a global salt and a non-atomic write. Both fixes are now what makes the security/persistence story defensible.
- + **The client kept the scope honest.** "Don't redesign; the look is what we agreed on" in round one stopped me sliding into endless visual tweaking. "Ship it" in round three stopped me adding features I didn't have time to test.
- + **E2 caught the naive-user issues.** The critical colour, the dead settings icon, the XP counter going nowhere – all things I'd missed because I'd grown blind to them.

- + **E1 surfaced the format gap.** The monthly view wasn't even in the planning storyboard at the level of detail it ended up at; E1's "month at a glance" request shaped the v0.3 calendar grid.

Client sign-off

14 May 2026



DISTORTIO 14/05/2026, 17:02

What we sketched in planning is what got built. The schedule it gives me actually matches how I'd plan my own week, but faster, and on the days I just need to be told what to do, it tells me. Happy to call this done.

Standing survey/Interview questions

This can be used for any follow-ups and can be filled independently or as an interview.

A. Setup & first run.

1. How long did it take from receiving the folder to seeing the application running?
2. Did the installation steps in the README work the first time? If not, where did they fail?
3. What was your first impression on launch, before clicking anything?

B. Account & Security

4. How obvious was it that you needed to create an account first?
5. Were the username and password validation messages clear when they appeared?
6. Did you feel comfortable typing a password into the app? If not, what concerned you?
7. After logging out and logging back in, was your data exactly as you left it?

C. Daily use

8. Walk me through how you used the dashboard. Which numbers did you look at first?
9. Did the priority order match the order you would have chosen? When it differed, who was right?
10. Did the cushion gauge feel like a useful pressure signal, or was it noise?
11. Did the weekly view land study blocks in slots that worked for you in practice?
12. Did the monthly view help you see anything you couldn't see on the weekly view?
13. If you adjusted the progress slider on a task, did it save correctly and stay saved?

D. Customisation

14. Was it clear how to add your own subjects?
15. Was it clear how to add your own class periods to the 14-day timetable?
16. Did the theme switch (light/dark) behave the way you expected?

17. Did the accessibility toggles (high contrast, focus highlights, and zoom) help you or feel unused?

E. Errors & data safety

18. Did you encounter any error messages? Were they understandable?
19. Did anything you typed in fail to save?
20. Did the application crash, freeze, or behave inconsistently at any point?

F. Closing

21. On a scale of 1–5, how confident are you that this application would help a real Year-12 student plan their week?
22. What is the single most important thing to fix or add in a v1.1?
23. What is the single best thing about the application as it stands?
24. Anything we did not ask about that you want to record?